

# Plato's Cave and the Shadows of Science

- In Plato's allegory, prisoners are chained inside a cave, facing a wall. Behind them, real objects pass before a fire, casting shadows.
- The prisoners see only shadows — **surface appearances** — and mistake them for reality.
- Modern physics, having banished metaphysics, often studies only shadows:
  - Quantum field theory is a theory of particles, not of fields.
  - Quantum mechanics is a theory of particles, not of fields.
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- Heim's work is the act of turning around:
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- Instead of treating observation as neutral, Heim models the **semantic conditions** that give rise to fields and causality.



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